

LinguaLounge IPA Reference Sheet: Russian

Base language: English - / / = broad phonemic IPA, [] = common phonetic realization.
Regional pronunciation can vary.

Scope

Standard Russian. Examples use [] for common surface pronunciation where vowel reduction or palatalization matters.

VOWELS

Category	IPA symbols
Stressed vowel phonemes	/a e i o u ɨ/
Common reduced phones	[ɐ ə ɪ] in unstressed syllables
Iotated letters	я /ja/, е /je/, ё /jo/, ю /ju/ word-initially or after vowels/signs

CONSONANTS

Category	IPA symbols
Plosives	/p b t d k g/ with hard/soft pairs for many consonants
Fricatives	/f v s z ʂ ʐ ɣ x/
Affricates	/tʂ tɕ/
Nasals	/m n/ plus palatalized /mʲ nʲ/
Liquids / approximant	/r rʲ l lʲ j/

ALPHABET AND COMMON SPELLING VALUES

The table gives common learner-safe values. Some letters have additional values in loanwords, names, or regional speech.

Letter / spelling	Main IPA value	Example	Notes
А а	/a/	мама ['mamə]	Unstressed a often reduces.
Б б	/b/	банк [bank]	Final б devoices to [p].
В в	/v/	вода [ve'da]	Final в devoices to [f].
Г г	/g/	гора [ge'ra]	
Д д	/d/	дом [dom]	Final д devoices to [t].
Е е	/je/ or palatalizing /e/	ель [jelʲ], лес [lʲes]	After consonants, it usually palatalizes them.
Ё ё	/jo/ or palatalizing /o/	ёлка ['jolkə]	Always stressed in normal Russian words.
Ж ж	/z/	жук [zʊk]	Normally hard.
З з	/z/	зима [zʲɪ'ma]	Soft before softening vowels/signs.
И и	/i/	мир [mʲɪr]	Often softens the previous consonant.
Й й	/j/	май [maj]	
К к	/k/	кот [kot]	
Л л	/l, lʲ/	лампа ['lampə], лес [lʲes]	
М м	/m, mʲ/	мама ['mamə]	
Н н	/n, nʲ/	нос [nos], нет [nʲet]	
О о	/o/ stressed; reduced unstressed	он [on], вода [ve'da]	Unstressed o is usually not [o].
П п	/p/	папа ['papə]	
Р р	/r, rʲ/	рука [rʊ'ka], река [rʲɪ'ka]	Trilled/tapped rhotic.
С с	/s, sʲ/	сон [son], семья [sʲemʲɪ]	
Т т	/t, tʲ/	там [tam], тень [tʲenʲ]	
У у	/u/	утро ['utrə]	
Ф ф	/f/	факт [fakt]	
Х х	/x/	хлеб [xlʲep]	
Ц ц	/t͡s/	центр ['t͡sentr]	Normally hard.
Ч ч	/t͡ʃ/	чай [t͡ʃaj]	Normally soft.
Ш ш	/ʃ/	школа ['ʃkolə]	Normally hard.
Щ щ	/ɕ:/	щука ['ɕ:ukə]	Long soft fricative.
Ъ ъ	no sound	подъезд [pəd'jest]	Hard sign: separates a consonant from /j/.
Ы ы	/ɨ/	сын [sɨn]	Never word-initial in native words.
Ь ь	no sound; palatalization	день [dʲenʲ]	Soft sign.
Э э	/e/	это ['etə]	Non-iotated e-like vowel.
Ю ю	/ju/ or palatalizing /u/	юг [juk], люк [lʲuk]	
Я я	/ja/ or palatalizing /a/	я [ja], пять [pʲætʲ]	

IMPORTANT SPELLING AND PRONUNCIATION NOTES

Stress	Stress is movable and is normally not written. Use a dictionary for correct stress.
Vowel reduction	Unstressed o/a commonly reduce to [ɐ] or [ə]. Unstressed e/я often sound closer to [ɪ].
Palatalization	е, ё, и, ю, я and ь often make the preceding consonant soft: н /n/ vs нь /nʲ/.
Final devoicing	Voiced obstruents devoice word-finally: дуб [dub], город ['gorɐt̚].